Husain, who stopped many a meal midway to do a quick sketch or two. De's descriptions of watching Husain work are touching and reflect the genuine affection she feels for the much-misunderstood man and his art.

"(...) the lines were faultless, ceaseless, sure and unerring as he continued chatting, his fingers moving steadily over the surface of whichever material he could find at that moment. Waiters, managers, restaurant guests would watch in wonder and marvel, awestruck by his genius. He'd look up and do one of two things—if he was in a generous mood, he would give the drawing to whoever was at the table; at other times, he'd carefully fold the paper napkin and place it in his jacket pocket."

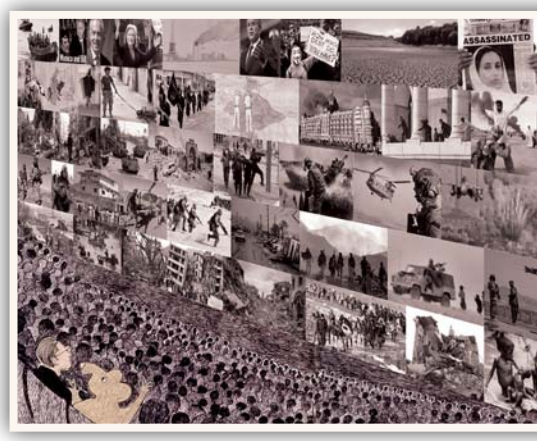
Towards the end of our conversation, I asked her if she had ever felt the need to keep track of her own sales figures; authors these days are expected to have an entrepreneurial mindset, apparently. De chuckled and said, "Throughout my career, I have never paid attention to sales figures—or algorithms, as everybody keeps telling me these days. That's on me, perhaps I should have done more, but I can't change the way I am now and I hope I never have to!" ■

Aditya Mani Jha

BOOKS

ODE TO A FRIEND





NACHIKET PATWARDHAN

Saeed Mirza's book about the late filmmaker Kundan Shah is not a biography but a charming tribute to their long comradeship

When a director's first film is an all-time classic—in this case, *Jaane Bhi Do Yaaro* (1983)—his life is primed for the tough-act-to-follow storyline. Mercifully, Kundan Shah has directed at least three TV series that will ensure he is remembered: *Yeh Jo Hai Zindagi* (1984), *Nukkad* (1986-1987) and *Wagle Ki Duniya* (1988-1990). Several other ventures weren't as successful. Yet, Shah, who died in 2017, is etched in memory as the herald of an everyday sensibility that's as interesting and warm as it is confrontational and unsettling.

Now, there's a book to get to know the man behind the filmmaker, not a biography but a set of non-linear reminiscences by his friend and associate Saeed Mirza, himself a director of repute and a batchmate of Shah's at the Film and Television Institute of India, Pune. They graduated together in 1976.

An articulate man nearing 80, Mirza has much material and lots to say. His recollections of Shah are warm and funny, told with charm and a straight face. They are interspersed with Mirza's observations about politics and life. The jerky read may not be to everybody's taste. What makes it work is how Shah's personality appears piece by piece.

They weren't the most likely of friends, as Mirza describes. The author came from a family steeped in the cinema world, the son of screenwriter Akhtar Mirza (*Waqt*, 1965). Shah came from an ordinary business family with little cultural exposure; he had to work against the grain to cultivate his interest in cinema and literature. Mirza highlights this in good measure, offering glimpses into how Shah developed his blend of the ordinary and the spectacular.

We read about the film Shah made for his final year in college: "I did not have a clue about his script idea...I wondered what the film was about. It was a gem. A piece of controlled anarchy..." And instantly, the riotous, laugh-your-guts-out climax of *Jaane Bhi Do Yaaro* comes into perspective.

When he was jobless in England, Shah did a crash course in typing and worked for over two years as a clerk in an accounting firm, typing letters of credit. Later, he was to tell an assistant that his typing speed was 120 words per minute and that he could type in Hindi, too. Why? "It was his back-up in case he could not find another job."

Mirza's observations on politics and current affairs are important. But a man of his ability could have treated them better. The best parts of the book come from his memory of Shah; he takes us close to a brave and tireless filmmaker whose sharp eye and ear, whose integrity is missed in these noisy, compromised times. ■

Sopan Joshi

I KNOW THE PSYCHOLOGY OF RATS
By Saeed Mirza
TULIKA BOOKS
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